Speech Sample Pack

Free · 4 sample speeches, a cue-card example and the questions we ask · TCH Works

Most people asked to give a speech have the same three worries: it won't be funny, it'll go on too long, and they'll lose their place. This pack shows what a speech built around those worries looks like, for the four occasions people ask about most at this time of year: the Christmas party, a retirement, a leaving do, and a wedding.

Every name, workplace and story in this pack is made up. They show the shape and tone. A paid speech is built only from the people, dates and stories you send us, and nothing that would embarrass anyone in the room.

Three rules every speech in this pack follows

Open with the room, not yourself. A line that gets a smile in the first ten seconds settles your nerves and theirs.

One story beats five facts. A single small moment (the cup of tea, the frozen pipe) says more than a list of qualities.

Land on a toast. Ending with 'please raise your glasses' tells everyone exactly when to clap, so you never trail off.

What's inside

Pages 2–3: four sample speeches with word counts and read-aloud times.

Page 4: how a speech becomes printable cue cards, so you never read from a phone.

Page 5: the questionnaire we send every client, with space for your answers, and how to book.

How long is a good speech?

At a relaxed speaking pace of about 130 words a minute with pauses for laughs: a Christmas toast is 200–300 words (about 2 minutes), a leaving or retirement speech 300–550 words (3–4 minutes), and a wedding speech 650–900 words (5–7 minutes). Longer than that and the room starts looking at the bar.

Written with AI assistance and checked line by line by the TCH Works team.

1. Christmas party toast

For: Office manager, small accountancy firm, 14 staff · **Brief:** Wanted: under 2 minutes, light, everyone included, nothing about anyone's mistakes.

166 words · about 1 min 15 s read aloud at a relaxed pace

Right, can I have everyone's attention for two minutes? I promise it's two. Gary's timing me, and he's an accountant, so he'll know.

This year we moved to new software, survived January self-assessment on four coffee machines' worth of caffeine, and welcomed two new faces. Priya, Josh, you joined in March and somehow you're still here. Thank you for choosing to stay.

I want to say thank you properly. To Helen, who answered the phone on the 31st of January more times than anyone should. To the payroll team, who never once let a mistake leave the building. And to everyone who covered for someone when life got in the way. Nobody saw that on a spreadsheet, but I did.

Next year we've got a new client portal, a new printer that might actually work, and the same brilliant people. That last one's the bit I care about.

So please raise your glasses. To a team that makes the hard months feel shorter. Merry Christmas, everyone.

2. Retirement speech (given by a colleague)

For: Head of department, for a school caretaker retiring after 31 years · **Brief:** Wanted: 2 to 3 minutes, warm, two stories, ends with a toast. Staff and some families present.

279 words · about 2 min 15 s read aloud at a relaxed pace

Good evening, everyone. I've been asked to say a few words about Pete, which is a challenge, because Pete himself has never used more than a few words when a nod would do.

Pete started here in 1995. The school had one computer, a coal boiler, and a head teacher who still used a cane as a pointer. Thirty-one years later, the computers have multiplied, the boiler has gone, and Pete has outlasted six head teachers. I'm told he's not taking questions about which one was his favourite.

If you've worked here, you'll have a Pete story. Mine is from my first week. I'd locked myself out of the science block at seven in the morning, in the rain, holding thirty trays of cress. Pete appeared out of nowhere with a key, an umbrella and a cup of tea. He didn't say a word. He just handed me the tea. I've since learned that this is how he solves most problems.

The other story everyone tells is the snow of 2010. The roads were shut, the head had already sent the closure text, and Pete walked in anyway, two miles, to make sure the pipes didn't freeze. When someone asked why, he said, 'Well, somebody had to.' That's Pete. Somebody had to, and for thirty-one years it was him.

Pete, the building will miss you. We'll miss you more. Your allotment, your grandchildren and, I'm told, a caravan in Norfolk are about to get the best of you, and they're lucky.

So would you all please stand and raise a glass. To Pete. Thank you for every key, every cup of tea and every frozen pipe that never burst.

3. Leaving do speech (given by the person leaving)

For: Customer service team leader moving to a new job after 6 years · **Brief:** Wanted: under 2 minutes, funny but not bitter, thank the team by name, no digs at the company.

204 words · about 1 min 30 s read aloud at a relaxed pace

I've been told I have to do a speech, which is ironic, because for six years my job has been talking to people who didn't want to talk to me.

When I started here, I was given a headset, a laminated script and a desk next to the radiator that only worked in July. I'd like to thank that radiator for teaching me resilience.

Seriously though, I want to thank a few people. Amira, for showing me how to calm down a customer without ever raising your voice. I still don't know how you do it. Leon, for the Friday quiz, which I never won once, and which I believe is fixed. And Sam, for being the best manager I've had, and for pretending not to notice the biscuit drawer.

The thing I'll miss most isn't the job. It's the moment at five to six, when the phones finally go quiet and somebody says, 'Who's for the pub?' That's when this stopped being an office and started being a team.

I'm only going twenty minutes up the road, so this isn't goodbye. It's 'see you at the quiz', where I fully expect to lose again.

Thank you, all of you. It's been a privilege.

4. Father of the bride, opening and close

For: Dad of the bride at a spring wedding; full speech was 6 minutes · **Brief:** Wanted: proud, a bit soppy, one gentle joke about the groom, a word for late grandparents.

188 words · about 1 min 30 s read aloud at a relaxed pace (excerpt shown)

Good afternoon, everyone. On behalf of my wife, Carol, and me, thank you for being here. Some of you have come a long way, and Uncle Ray has come from the bar, which on a day like this is further than it sounds.

Thirty years ago, a nurse handed me a very small, very cross baby, and I remember thinking, 'I have no idea what I'm doing.' I'm pleased to say that feeling never really went away. But Emma, you made it easy. You were funny and stubborn and kind, usually all before breakfast.

[Middle of speech: three stories about Emma growing up, the first meeting with Liam, and welcoming his family.]

Before I finish, I'd like us to remember two people who would have loved today: my mum, Joan, and Carol's dad, Frank. Joan would have cried in the church, and Frank would have told her off for it, then cried himself. They're in our hearts, and in Emma's middle name.

Liam, I've watched you look after my daughter, and I couldn't ask for more. Emma, you look beautiful, and your mum and I are so proud of you.

So please stand and raise your glasses. To the bride and groom. To Emma and Liam.

From speech to cue cards

Every speech we write comes with printable cue cards. Here are the first three cards from speech 1.

1 / 4

Two minutes. Gary's timing me.

(pause for laugh) · new software, January, two new faces · Priya, Josh: 'still here'

2 / 4

Thank you, properly.

Helen: phones on the 31st · payroll: no mistakes out the door · covering for each other (slow down)

3 / 4

Next year.

portal · printer 'might actually work' (pause) · same brilliant people (look round the room)

Why cue cards beat reading the whole speech

- ☐ Big first line on each card: glance down, look up, say it to the room.
- ☐ Small prompts underneath, not full sentences, so you sound like you're talking, not reading.
- ☐ Stage notes in brackets ('pause for laugh', 'slow down') where nerves make people rush.
- ☐ Numbered cards, printed one-sided on card or thick paper. If you drop them, you'll be fine.
- ☐ Practise out loud three times: once alone, once timed, once to someone who'll be honest.

The speech questionnaire

Answer these and you have most of what a good speech needs, whether you write it yourself or hire us.

1. What's the occasion, the date, and how long have you got to speak?

2. Who are you to the person (or people), and who will be in the room?

3. Three or four stories or moments that sum them up. Small is fine.

4. Three words other people would use to describe them.

5. Anyone to thank or remember? (hosts, family, colleagues, people no longer with us)

6. How do you talk? (dry, soppy, loud, nervous) Anything to steer clear of?

Want us to write it?

Standard, £25. Up to 5 minutes (about 650 words), written from your answers, Word + PDF with printable cue cards, back in 2 working days, one round of changes.

`https://buy.stripe.com/eVqfZg5Om5eR1RC3vP2881o?client_reference_id=svc-speech-standard`

Premium, £45. Up to 10 minutes, two openings to choose from, a shorter back-up version in case timings change on the day, next working day, two rounds of changes.

`https://buy.stripe.com/fZudR83Ge0YB53O0jD2881p?client_reference_id=svc-speech-premium`

After you pay, we email you this questionnaire. Eulogies, awards nights or polishing a speech you've started: email tchworks.shop@agentmail.to for a fixed quote. Full details: https://www.tchworks.co.uk/services/speech-writing/?src=speech-sample

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